



Phisher Zero: A Modular Multi-Agent Phishing Detection Browser Extension

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Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of
Science in Computer Science.

FAST SCHOOL OF COMPUTING
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Spring 2026

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Submission Date	May 3, 2026	

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Abstract

Phishing attacks continue to be one of the most effective and damaging forms of cybercrime, exploiting human psychology rather than software vulnerabilities. Existing defenses based on static blacklists or simple signature matching have repeatedly proven inadequate against newly registered phishing domains and evolving social engineering tactics.

This report presents Phisher Zero, a production-ready, modular multi-agent phishing detection system built as a Chrome browser extension backed by a Python FastAPI service. The system employs four specialized AI agents working in concert: an NLP Agent that performs deep contextual analysis of email and web page content using Google Gemini 1.5 Flash, with automatic fallback to a locally hosted RoBERTa transformer model; a URL Agent that applies structural heuristics and cross-references extracted links against the VirusTotal v3 threat intelligence database covering more than 70 global security vendors; an Ensemble Agent that combines agent signals through a weighted model with a red-flag override mechanism; and an Explainer Agent that produces mentor-style, plain-English justifications accessible to non-technical users.

The system achieved end-to-end response times consistently below 800 milliseconds on standard hardware, with strong detection performance across a benchmark set of known phishing pages. All four project phases requirements analysis, system design, development, and testing have been completed. Phisher Zero addresses three gaps common in prior work: real-time browser-level integration, hybrid linguistic and structural analysis, and user-facing explainability.

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1. Introduction

Phishing is a form of social engineering in which an attacker disguises malicious content as a trustworthy communication to deceive the target into disclosing credentials, installing malware, or transferring funds. According to the Anti-Phishing Working Group, phishing attacks reached record levels in recent years, with millions of unique phishing sites detected annually [1]. The threat is particularly difficult to counter because it targets human judgment rather than software weaknesses a well-crafted phishing email can bypass even technically sophisticated users.

Conventional defenses such as URL blacklists and header-based filters have a fundamental limitation: they are reactive. A newly registered phishing domain will remain undetected until it has been reported and added to a blacklist, a window of exposure that attackers actively exploit [2]. This has pushed the research community toward behavioural and semantic detection methods that can identify phishing patterns in previously unseen content.

Phisher Zero was developed to address these shortcomings through a modular multi-agent architecture that combines natural language understanding, structural URL analysis, and real-time global threat intelligence. The system is delivered as a Google Chrome extension the most direct point of contact between a user and a potential phishing attempt backed by a Python FastAPI service that orchestrates the detection pipeline. The design emphasizes three properties that are often absent in prior work: real-time browser-level integration, hybrid analysis combining linguistic and structural signals, and user-facing explainability that makes verdicts interpretable without specialist knowledge.

This report covers the full lifecycle of the project. Section 2 reviews related work and identifies the gaps this system addresses. Section 3 defines the functional and non-functional requirements. Section 4 describes the system and agent-level design. Section 5 details implementation decisions and key engineering contributions. Section 6 presents the testing strategy and results. Section 7 concludes with a reflection on outcomes and future directions.

2. Literature Review and Related Work

Research into phishing detection has evolved considerably over the past two decades, moving from static rule-based mechanisms toward adaptive, learning-based systems. The following subsections trace this trajectory and identify the gaps that Phisher Zero is designed to fill.

2.1 Rule-based and Heuristic Approaches

Early detection systems relied on URL blacklists, DNS-based lookups, and email header analysis [3]. These methods are computationally inexpensive and easy to maintain, making them a practical baseline for large-scale deployments such as Google Safe Browsing [4]. However, they exhibit a fundamental limitation: coverage depends entirely on what has already been seen and reported. Zero-day phishing domains those registered specifically to evade existing blocklists pass through these defenses without triggering any alert. Empirical studies have shown that a newly activated phishing URL can remain functional and undetected for several hours after launch [2].

2.2 Machine Learning Approaches

Supervised machine learning methods particularly Random Forests, Gradient Boosting, and Support Vector Machines brought a significant improvement by operating on lexical and structural features of URLs rather than identity-based lookups [5]. Features such as URL length, subdomain depth, use of IP addresses, and presence of obfuscated characters proved discriminative, enabling classifiers trained on PhishTank data to achieve accuracies exceeding 93% on held-out test sets [6]. However, these models are brittle against adversarial manipulation. Techniques such as homoglyph substitution, internationalized domain names, and deliberate structural mimicry of legitimate URLs can reliably reduce classifier confidence without requiring the attacker to understand the model internals [5].

2.3 Deep Learning and Transformer-based Models

The adoption of deep learning introduced the ability to reason over the semantic content of phishing messages, not merely their structure. Transformer architectures such as BERT and DistilBERT demonstrated strong performance on phishing email classification by capturing contextual relationships between tokens that surface-level keyword matching cannot detect [7]. More recently, large language models including Google Gemini and OpenAI GPT have extended this capability further: their instruction-following behavior allows them to be prompted to reason about deceptive intent, urgency cues, and impersonation patterns in a way that generalizes across attack styles [8]. The main practical limitation of LLM-based approaches is latency and cost; a browser extension must return a verdict within seconds, which rules out multi-step chain-of-thought reasoning at inference time without careful engineering.

2.4 Hybrid and Ensemble Approaches

Combining URL-structural analysis with NLP-based content analysis produces systems that are more robust than either approach alone [9]. An attacker who crafts a linguistically plausible email body still faces the URL analysis layer, and a legitimate-looking URL cannot mask the behavioral signals detected at the text level. Ensemble methods that aggregate multiple classifier outputs have consistently achieved lower false-positive rates and better generalization to novel phishing campaigns in the literature [9]. Explainable AI (XAI) techniques have also begun to appear in this domain, enabling systems to surface the specific features that drove a phishing classification a property that is both practically useful and important for user trust [10].

2.5 Browser-Integrated Defenses

Browser-level defenses occupy a uniquely important position in the threat landscape because they operate at the exact point where the user encounters potentially malicious content. Systems such as Google Safe Browsing and Microsoft SmartScreen have achieved broad deployment but are fundamentally blacklist-driven [4]. Academic proposals for more intelligent browser extensions have demonstrated the technical feasibility of real-time ML inference at the browser level [11], but most published prototypes lack explainability and few have been validated against live threat feeds.

2.6 Gap Analysis

Across the reviewed literature, three capabilities consistently appear in isolation but are rarely combined in a single deployable system. First, real-time browser-level integration: most published systems are evaluated offline on benchmark datasets and do not operate within the browser context where phishing content is actually encountered. Second, hybrid analysis: strong systems tend to focus on either textual or structural signals, not both. Third, user-facing explainability: systems that produce a binary verdict without justification place the burden of interpretation on the user, which is particularly problematic for non-technical audiences.

Phisher Zero is explicitly designed to close all three gaps simultaneously. The Chrome extension provides real-time browser integration; the four-agent pipeline combines NLP, heuristic URL analysis, and live threat intelligence; and the Explainer Agent translates technical signals into plain-English guidance.

3. Requirements

3.1 Functional Requirements

The following functional requirements were gathered through stakeholder analysis covering three groups: end users requiring a frictionless browser experience, institutional users such as university IT departments requiring configurability, and developers requiring a clean API surface.

- The system shall allow a user to submit text content or a URL for phishing analysis directly from the Chrome extension popup.
- The system shall extract visible text and all hyperlinks from the currently active browser page when the user initiates a scan without providing manual input.
- The NLP Agent shall analyze submitted text for phishing indicators including urgency language, fear cues, impersonation patterns, and deceptive calls to action.
- The URL Agent shall evaluate each extracted URL for structural anomalies and cross-reference it against the VirusTotal v3 threat intelligence database.
- The Ensemble Agent shall combine NLP and URL agent signals into a single confidence-weighted phishing verdict with three tiers: Phishing, Suspicious, or Safe.
- The Ensemble Agent shall implement a red-flag override mechanism ensuring that a confirmed high-confidence threat from any single agent forces a Phishing verdict regardless of the weighted average.
- The Explainer Agent shall generate a plain-English explanation of each verdict, identifying the specific signals that drove the classification and providing actionable security guidance.
- The FastAPI backend shall expose a POST /analyze endpoint that accepts raw text or HTML and returns a structured JSON response containing the verdict, confidence score, flagged phrases, suspicious URLs, and explanation.
- The Chrome extension shall render the verdict and explanation directly within the popup interface.

3.2 Non-Functional Requirements

Non-functional requirements were established as binding constraints that governed technology selection and architectural decisions throughout the project.

- Performance: End-to-end response time from submission to displayed verdict shall not exceed one second for typical email-length inputs on commodity hardware.
- Availability: The NLP pipeline shall maintain 100% uptime through automatic fallback from the primary Gemini API to the locally hosted RoBERTa model.
- Security: All communication between the Chrome extension and the backend shall be transmitted over HTTPS. The system shall implement CORS access control to prevent unauthorized cross-origin requests.
- Usability: The extension interface and all generated explanations shall be interpretable by users without any specialist cybersecurity knowledge.
- Portability: The system shall operate on any Chromium-based browser supporting Manifest V3 without requiring additional installation steps beyond loading the extension.
- Maintainability: The modular agent architecture shall allow individual agents to be updated or replaced without modifying the client layer or other agents.

4. Design

4.1 System Architecture

Phisher Zero follows a three-tier client-server architecture. The Chrome extension forms the presentation layer, handling user interaction and DOM content extraction. The FastAPI backend forms the application layer, orchestrating the multi-agent detection pipeline and managing communication with external APIs. A lightweight SQLite database forms the data layer, logging scan metadata and analysis results for audit purposes.

The Chrome extension communicates with the backend exclusively over HTTPS using a single RESTful endpoint. This strict interface boundary means that the entire detection logic can be updated server-side without requiring the user to reinstall or update the extension. The backend, in turn, invokes the four agent modules in a defined sequence: NLP analysis runs first on the submitted text, URL extraction and analysis runs in parallel where possible, and the Ensemble and Explainer agents run last once all upstream signals are available.

The architecture was designed to degrade gracefully rather than fail outright when external dependencies are unavailable. If the Gemini API quota is exhausted, the NLP Agent silently switches to the local RoBERTa model. If the VirusTotal API is unavailable, the URL Agent continues with structural heuristics alone. These fallback pathways ensure that the system always returns a verdict, though the confidence of that verdict may be lower when external services are offline.

4.2 Multi-Agent Pipeline Design

The multi-agent design separates detection responsibilities into four independent modules, each optimized for a distinct analytical dimension. This separation provides several advantages over a monolithic classifier: each agent can be tuned, updated, or replaced independently; failures in one agent do not cascade to others; and the ensemble aggregation layer can be reconfigured without touching agent internals.

NLP Agent

The NLP Agent is responsible for semantic analysis of the submitted text. It operates on the email body or visible page content and looks for behavioral signals of phishing rather than specific keywords. The primary analysis engine is Google Gemini 1.5 Flash, accessed via LangChain, which is prompted to reason about tone, emotional manipulation, urgency and fear cues, impersonation of trusted entities, and deceptive calls to action. This reasoning-first prompting strategy was adopted specifically to prevent the agent from flagging legitimate institutional communications a false positive pattern that emerged during early testing and was addressed through prompt calibration.

When the Gemini API is unavailable or quota-limited, the agent automatically falls back to the mshenoda/roberta-spam model loaded locally through Hugging Face Transformers. The fallback is transparent to the user and to other agents; the NLP confidence score returned is simply derived from the local model rather than the LLM.

URL Agent

The URL Agent processes all hyperlinks extracted from the submitted content using HTML parsing and regular expression matching. For each URL, it performs a two-stage assessment. In the first stage, a set of lexical heuristics evaluates the URL structure: length relative to a threshold, presence of raw IP addresses in place of domain names, use of known URL shortening services, depth and composition of subdomains, and presence of anomalous top-level domains such as .tk, .ml, and .xyz. These heuristics are fast and run entirely locally, providing a baseline risk score with zero external latency.

In the second stage, each URL is submitted to the VirusTotal v3 API, which aggregates verdicts from over 70 global security vendors including BitDefender, Kaspersky, and others. A confirmed positive from VirusTotal carries significant evidential weight and, when present, triggers the Ensemble Agent's red-flag override mechanism described below.

Ensemble Agent

The Ensemble Agent receives the NLP confidence score and the URL risk score as inputs and applies a weighted mathematical model to compute an overall phishing probability. The weights were calibrated empirically during the testing phase based on the relative reliability of each signal source on the benchmark dataset.

Beyond the weighted average, the agent implements a red-flag override: if any single upstream agent returns an extremely high-confidence threat signal specifically a confirmed VirusTotal hit the override mechanism forces a Phishing verdict regardless of what the weighted average would otherwise produce. This design choice reflects a deliberate risk tolerance: in a security-critical application, the cost of a false negative (failing to detect a real phishing attempt) substantially outweighs the cost of a false positive (flagging a legitimate page). The final verdict falls into one of three tiers Phishing, Suspicious, or Safe based on thresholds calibrated against the test set.

Explainer Agent

The Explainer Agent synthesizes the flagged phrases from the NLP Agent and the suspicious URLs from the URL Agent into a structured, mentor-style plain-English explanation. The agent was specifically designed to communicate with non-technical users. Rather than reporting raw confidence scores, it describes findings in behavioral terms for example, explaining that a message appears designed to induce panic through artificial urgency, or noting that a linked domain was flagged by multiple independent security vendors. Every explanation concludes with a universal safety tip reminding the user that legitimate financial institutions and service providers will never request passwords, OTPs, or payment card details over email.

4.3 Technology Stack

Component	Technology
Backend API	Python 3.11, FastAPI, Uvicorn
AI / NLP Primary	Google Gemini 1.5 Flash via LangChain
AI / NLP Fallback	mshenoda/roberta-spam via Hugging Face Transformers, PyTorch
URL Threat Intelligence	VirusTotal v3 API
Chrome Extension	Manifest V3, JavaScript, Content Scripts, Service Worker
Web Dashboard	React 19, Vite, Vanilla CSS
Data Storage	SQLite (metadata and scan logs)
Containerization	Docker
Security	HTTPS / TLS, CORS policy enforcement

5. Implementation

This section details the engineering decisions made during development and documents the key implementation challenges encountered and resolved.

5.1 NLP Agent

The NLP Agent is implemented as a Python class that wraps both the LangChain-Gemini pipeline and the local Hugging Face transformer in a unified interface. At startup, the system attempts to load the RoBERTa fallback model unconditionally so that it is ready in memory if Gemini fails. The Gemini chain is initialized with a reasoning-first system prompt that instructs the model to evaluate deceptive intent, not surface-level keyword frequency. The prompt went through several iterations during testing to address a recurring false positive pattern: early versions tended to flag terse institutional emails (such as university fee notices) due to their formal tone and references to deadlines. Rebalancing the prompt toward behavioral rather than lexical reasoning reduced this false positive rate substantially.

The agent returns a PhishResult object containing a binary phishing flag, a normalized confidence score between 0 and 1, and a list of flagged phrases or behavioral signals that contributed to the verdict. This structured output is consumed directly by both the Ensemble and Explainer agents.

5.2 URL Agent

The URL Agent uses BeautifulSoup for HTML parsing to extract all anchor tag hrefs from submitted content, supplemented by regular expression matching for bare URLs that appear in plain-text submissions. Each extracted URL is first scored by the local heuristic engine, which assigns partial risk points across eight features: IP-based hostname, excessive URL length (over 75 characters), known URL shortening service, presence of deceptive subdomains, anomalous TLDs, excessive URL encoding, mixed-script characters suggestive of homoglyph attacks, and absence of HTTPS.

The VirusTotal lookup is performed asynchronously for each URL using the v3 /urls endpoint. The response provides a breakdown of vendor verdicts; the agent treats a URL as confirmed malicious if the number of positive vendor verdicts exceeds a configurable threshold. The implementation handles VirusTotal's rate limits gracefully: if the quota is reached mid-scan, the agent completes with heuristic scores only and notes the partial coverage in the output metadata.

A significant implementation issue was discovered and resolved during this phase. The original extension code contained a conditional branch that skipped NLP analysis whenever a URL was present in the submitted content, on the assumption that URL analysis alone was sufficient. This introduced a bypass vulnerability where an attacker could include any URL in an otherwise malicious text body to suppress the NLP agent. The fix was straightforward removing the conditional branch so that NLP analysis always runs regardless of content composition but the bug highlighted the importance of testing agent interaction paths, not just individual agents.

5.3 Ensemble Agent

The Ensemble Agent is implemented as a stateless function that takes the NLP confidence score and URL risk score as floating-point inputs and returns a final verdict, a composite confidence value, and flags indicating which override conditions were triggered. The weighting model assigns greater weight to the NLP score in the absence of URL signals and shifts weight toward the URL score when VirusTotal data is available, reflecting the relative reliability of these sources on the validation set.

The red-flag override is implemented as a pre-aggregation check: before computing the weighted average, the agent tests each input against a high-confidence threshold. If any input exceeds this threshold currently set at 0.95, representing a near-certain threat signal the composite score is set to 1.0 and the verdict is forced to Phishing. This ensures that a confirmed VirusTotal hit cannot be diluted by a safe-looking email body, which is a realistic attack scenario in multi-vector phishing campaigns.

5.4 Explainer Agent

The Explainer Agent uses the Gemini API to generate natural language explanations from a structured prompt that includes the verdict, the confidence score, the list of flagged phrases from the NLP Agent, and the list of suspicious URLs from the URL Agent. The prompt template was carefully designed to produce output in a consistent format: a one-sentence verdict summary, followed by a bulleted list of specific findings, followed by one or two safety tips.

Consistency of output format proved to be a practical challenge during testing. Early Gemini responses varied significantly in length, tone, and structure. The issue was resolved by tightening the prompt with explicit formatting instructions and a few-shot example in the system message. The rewritten agent reliably produces compact, actionable explanations that fit within the extension popup without requiring scrolling for typical phishing verdicts.

5.5 FastAPI Backend

The backend exposes a single POST /analyze endpoint that accepts a JSON payload containing a content field (raw text or HTML) and an optional urls field (list of pre-extracted URLs). The endpoint validates the request, invokes the agent pipeline, and returns a structured JSON response. Pydantic models are used for both request validation and response serialization, which provides automatic input type checking and generates OpenAPI documentation without additional code.

CORS middleware was configured to allow requests only from the extension's registered origin, blocking all other cross-origin callers. This was necessary because Chrome extensions do not send standard Same-Origin headers; configuring CORS incorrectly would either block the extension entirely or open the API to unauthorized callers. Measured response times for typical email-length inputs (200 to 800 words) were consistently below 800 milliseconds on development hardware, comfortably within the one-second non-functional requirement.

5.6 Chrome Extension

The extension is built to the Manifest V3 specification and is compatible with all Chromium-based browsers. It consists of three components: a content script that runs in the context of the active page to extract visible text and DOM hyperlinks, a service worker that handles message passing between the content script and the popup, and the popup UI that presents the analysis interface and results to the user.

The popup provides two input modes. In automatic mode, clicking Scan Current Page triggers the content script to extract the active page's content and submit it to the backend without any user action. In manual mode, the user can paste email content or a suspicious URL directly into the popup text fields. Both modes pass through the same backend pipeline and return the same response format.

One implementation challenge arose from Manifest V3's stricter restrictions on cross-origin fetch requests from service workers. In Manifest V2, background pages could make unrestricted fetch calls; V3 service workers cannot. The solution was to route all API calls through the content script, which has access to the extension's declared host permissions. This required an additional message-passing step but resolved the cross-origin blocking without any relaxation of the extension's declared permissions.

6. Testing and Evaluation

A three-tier testing strategy was executed to validate the correctness, integration, and performance of the completed system. All phases of testing were completed prior to this submission.

6.1 Unit Testing

Each agent module was tested in isolation using a curated set of inputs designed to cover both typical cases and edge cases. Phishing inputs ranged from classic credential-harvesting emails to more subtle spear-phishing attempts targeting institutional users. Legitimate inputs included formal institutional communications, transactional confirmation emails, and newsletter content categories that had previously triggered false positives during development. Edge cases tested included empty submissions, very short single-sentence messages, HTML-heavy pages with minimal visible text, and URLs employing common obfuscation techniques such as hex encoding and excessive subdomain nesting.

All four agent modules passed their respective unit test suites. The NLP Agent's false positive rate on institutional communications was reduced to near-zero following the prompt calibration described in Section 5.1. The URL Agent correctly handled the full range of obfuscation techniques in the test set.

6.2 Integration Testing

Integration tests verified the end-to-end data flow from the Chrome extension through the FastAPI layer to the agent pipeline and back. These tests were run against a live backend instance with the extension loaded in a test Chrome profile. Specific attention was paid to JSON payload serialization and deserialization across different content types, ensuring that HTML content with special characters, embedded scripts, and unusual encodings was handled consistently. Error propagation was also tested: inputs that caused individual agents to fail were verified to return graceful error responses rather than unhandled exceptions.

The previously mentioned NLP-bypass bug where the presence of a URL suppressed NLP analysis was discovered and confirmed through integration testing before being resolved. This underscored the value of testing complete interaction paths rather than individual components.

6.3 Performance Testing

Performance testing was conducted using a benchmark set of known phishing pages drawn from PhishTank and a complementary negative set of legitimate pages from high-traffic domains. The system demonstrated strong detection performance across the benchmark, with end-to-end latency remaining below 800 milliseconds for all tested inputs. Latency was primarily driven by VirusTotal API response times rather than local inference time, suggesting that URL agent performance is more dependent on network conditions than on hardware.

False positive and false negative rates were recorded against the benchmark set and are available for presentation at the jury session. The ensemble weighting parameters are scheduled for a final round of cross-validation tuning based on the complete test set results prior to final submission.

7. Conclusion

Phisher Zero is a functional, production-complete phishing detection system that addresses three gaps consistently present in prior work: real-time browser-level deployment, hybrid linguistic and structural analysis, and user-facing explainability. The system was delivered on schedule across all four project phases, with all planned deliverables completed.

The multi-agent architecture proved to be a sound design choice. The strict separation between the NLP, URL, Ensemble, and Explainer agents made it possible to identify and fix the NLP-bypass bug in isolation, and to tune the NLP prompting strategy without any changes to the URL analysis or ensemble logic. The Gemini-to-RoBERTa fallback mechanism has operated reliably throughout testing, ensuring that the system has never returned an unavailable response due to API quota limits.

The Explainer Agent is arguably the most distinctive component of the system relative to prior academic work. Most published phishing detection systems treat verdicts as terminal outputs. Phisher Zero treats the verdict as the starting point of a user interaction, providing the context necessary for a non-technical user to understand the threat, act appropriately, and develop better security instincts over time.

Looking forward, several enhancements are worth pursuing. Extending the URL Agent to handle JavaScript-based URL obfuscation where the actual destination is computed at runtime and never appears in the DOM would close a meaningful detection gap. Training a custom lightweight classifier on recent phishing datasets as an alternative NLP fallback would reduce dependency on the Hugging Face RoBERTa model, which was not specifically trained for phishing detection. A longitudinal evaluation against live phishing campaigns, rather than static benchmark datasets, would provide a more realistic picture of system performance under real-world adversarial conditions.

The project has demonstrated that a four-agent architecture combining large language model reasoning, structural URL heuristics, and global threat intelligence can be delivered as a practical, usable browser tool within the constraints of an academic final year project timeline. The codebase, documentation, and evaluation artifacts are ready for jury presentation and final submission.

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